

actions. The minute we forgot about this point, the “Enlightenment” came to drill it into our heads for a second time.

I’d rather degrade us humans to a level certainly above other known animals but not quite on a par with the ideal Olympian man who can absorb philosophical statements and act accordingly. Indeed, if philosophy were *that* effective, the self-help section of the local bookstore would be of some use in consoling souls experiencing pain—but it isn’t. We forget to philosophize when under strain.

I’ll end this section on prediction with the following two lessons, one very brief (for the small matters), one rather lengthy (for the large, important decisions).

Being a Fool in the Right Places

The lesson for the small is: *be human!* Accept that being human involves some amount of epistemic arrogance in running your affairs. Do not be ashamed of that. Do not try to always withhold judgment—opinions are the stuff of life. Do not try to avoid predicting—yes, after this diatribe about prediction I am *not* urging you to stop being a fool. Just be a fool in the right places.*

What you should avoid is unnecessary dependence on large-scale harmful predictions—those and only those. Avoid the big subjects that may hurt your future: be fooled in small matters, not in the large. Do not listen to economic forecasters or to predictors in social science (they are mere entertainers), but do make your own forecast for the picnic. By all means, demand certainty for the next picnic; but avoid government social-security forecasts for the year 2040.

Know how to rank beliefs not according to their plausibility but by the harm they may cause.

Be Prepared

The reader might feel queasy reading about these general failures to see the future and wonder what to do. But if you shed the idea of full predictability, there are plenty of things to do provided you remain conscious of their limits. Knowing that you cannot predict does not mean that you cannot benefit from unpredictability.

The bottom line: be prepared! Narrow-minded prediction has an analgesic or therapeutic effect. Be aware of the numbing effect of magic numbers. Be prepared for all relevant eventualities.